All the Bright Places

By Jennifer Niven

VIOLET: **(Pg 316-318)** The first text comes in on Thursday. **The thing is, they were all perfect days.** As soon as I read it, I call Finch, but he's already turned the phone off and I go to voicemail. Instead of leaving a message, I text him back: **We're all so worried. I'm worried. My boyfriend is a missing person. Please call me.** Hours later, I hear from him again: **Not missing at all. Found.** I write immediately: **Where are you?** This time he doesn't answer. Two days later, Finch writes: **I am on the highest branch.** The next morning: **We are written in paint.** The next afternoon: **The glow of Ultraviolet.** The day after that: **A lake. A prayer. It's so lovely to be lovely in Private.**

And then everything goes quiet.

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INTRODUCTION

Every 40 seconds someone in the world commits suicide. Every 40 seconds someone is left behind to cope with the loss. And while those left behind often feel they could have -- should have -- done more; a mental illness left untreated, can be all-consuming and create a darkness from which there is no escape.

Theodore Finch experiences extreme highs and unbearable lows. But as he begins to descend into the darkness of bipolar disorder, Violet can't pull him from the quicksand.

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VIOLET: **(Pg 326-328)** On Sunday morning, around ten thirty, Kate Finch shows up at our door. She looks as if she hasn't slept in weeks.

KATE FINCH: Do you have any idea where Theo might be?

VIOLET: I don't hear from him anymore.

KATE FINCH: *(nodding)* Okay. Okay. It's just that he's been checking in every Saturday with Mom or me. I mean, every Saturday. We didn't hear from him yesterday, and then this morning we get this weird email.

VIOLET: She hands me a piece of paper. It's the email sent at 9:43 a.m *(reading aloud)* **I'm remembering the time we went to Indianapolis to eat at that pizza**

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place, the one with the organ that came up and out of the floor. Kate must have been eleven, I was ten, Decca was a baby. Mom was there. Dad too. When the organ started playing--so loud the tables shook--the light show started. Remember? It was like the aurora borealis. But what stays with me most is all of you. We were happy. We were good. Each and every one of us. The happy times went away for awhile, but they're coming back. Mom, forty-one's not old. Decca, sometimes there's beauty in tough words--it's all in how you read them. Kate, be careful with your own heart and remember that you're better than some guy. You're one of the best there is. You all are.

(handing back the e-mail – to Kate) I haven't [heard from him]. I'm sorry. *(to audience)* I promise to let her know if by some miracle he gets in touch with me, and then she goes away, and I shut the door. I lean against it because for some reason I feel the need to catch my breath.

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I go upstairs and turn on the computer and sign onto Facebook. There's a new message as of 9:47 a.m. **The words are written in The Waves: "If that blue could stay forever; if that hole could remain forever; if this moment could stay forever...I feel myself shining in the dark...I am arrayed. I am prepared. This is the momentary pause; the dark moment. The fiddlers have lifted their bows...This is my calling. This is my world. All is decided and ready...I am rooted but I flow. 'Come,' I say, 'come'."**

I write the only thing I can think of: **"Stay," I say, "stay".**

Something is wrong. I pick up the phone to call Kate and realize I don't have her number, so I drive to Finch's house. Kate, Decca and Mrs. Finch are there. When she sees me, Mrs. Finch starts to cry.

(Pg 333) The words are written in The Waves, he wrote on Facebook at 9:47 a.m. The water could be the Bloomington Empire Quarry or the Seven Pillars, but I have a pretty good idea where he might be. *(to*

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Mrs. Finch) I think he's gone back to one of the places we wandered, one of the places with water. I can give you directions and tell you exactly where to look for him. *(to audience)* She turns to me and lays her hand on my arm and squeezes hard.

MRS. FINCH: *(pleading)* I hate to ask you, but can you go? I'm just so---worried, and---I don't think I could---I mean, in case something were to---or if he were. *(crying)* I just really need you to bring him home.

VIOLET: **(Pg 334-335)** I call my parents to tell them I'll be home in a while. I drive faster than I normally do, and I remember the way without looking at the map. I am scarily, eerily calm. ***"If that blue could stay forever; if that hole could remain forever."*** There was nothing to make him last.

(Pg 335-336) His clothes on the bank [of Blue Hole] are folded neatly and stacked. I kneel beside the stack of clothes and lay my hand on them as if by doing so I can learn where he is and how long ago he came. The clothes are warm from the sun. **(Pg 336-337)** *(whispering)* Marco. *(louder)* Marco.

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At some point, I know: he's gone. He's not somewhere. He's nowhere. But as I dial 9-1-1, I think: ***He's not nowhere. He's not dead. He just found that other world.***

(Pg 352-353) That evening, I torture myself by reading our Facebook messages, going back to the very beginning. And even though he'll never read it, I open our notebook and start to write.

Letter to Someone Who Committed Suicide
By Violet Markey

Where are you? And why did you go? I guess I'll never know this. Was it because I tried to help? Because I didn't answer when you threw rocks at my window? What if I had answered? What would you have said to me? Would I have been able to talk you into staying or talk you out of doing what you did? Or would that have happened anyway?

Do you know my life is forever changed now? I used to think that was true because you came in and showed me Indiana, and in doing that, forced me out

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of my room and into the world. Even when we weren't wandering, even from the floor of your closet, you showed the world to me. I didn't know that my life forever changing would be because you loved me and then left, and in such a final way. I'll never forgive you for leaving me. I just wish you could forgive me. You saved my life. Why couldn't I save yours?

(Pg 374-375) Something pokes out of the [journal] --a white envelope. I turn the page and someone has written the words, ***"Then you will shine among them like stars in the sky."*** I pick up the envelope, and there is my name: "Ultraviolet Remarkey-able." Am I ready to hear what he thought of me? To hear how I let him down? My hands are shaking as I open the envelope. I begin to read:

You make me happy. Whenever you're around I'm safe inside your smile. You make me handsome. Whenever I feel my nose just seems a bit too round. You make me special and God knows I've longed to be that kind of guy to have around. You make me love you, And that could be

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the greatest thing my heart was ever fit to do . . .

I read and reread them until I know the words by heart. *(long pause)* **(Pg 361)** I loved Theodore Finch. He went away and I wish he hadn't, and I can never bring him back, and it hurts, but I like thinking about him. If I think about him, he won't be completely gone.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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